

In response, seven of the nine participants stated that, in addition to a family member, at least one outsider would be co-executor of their estates. Mr. Ring, a retired entrepreneur and grandfather of nine grandchildren, was one such participant. Mr. Ring had served as co-executor of several estates. He knew of situations in which the heirs to a grandparent's fortune were seriously spoiled children in their late twenties and thirties who did not have the training, discipline, or ambition to support the affluent lifestyle they had been conditioned to enjoy. Several of these adults still lived at home. All had been receiving outpatient care from their grandparents. But, as Mr. Ring explained, once the "well ran dry," problems arose. When the grandparents died, the grandchildren and parents became adversaries. Each generation felt it should receive the bulk of the estate's proceeds.

These experiences had had a profound influence on Mr. Ring. He realized that long before one passes away, one should select professionals to be co-executors. Consequently, over the years, he had developed close relationships with a highly skilled estate attorney and an outstanding tax accountant. Mr. Ring sought their advice before he retired, realizing that someday these professionals would likely act on his behalf to prevent, or at least reduce, the probability that his grandchildren would battle over his estate. Through the years he had also sought their counsel on how to "give without spoiling." Mr. Ring now gives gifts to his grandchildren, but not in the form of products or social privileges. And he never gives without first gaining the approval and blessings of his grandchildren's parents.

The trusts for the grandchildren are controlled.... Money is distributed only when each grandchild reaches certain maturity.... I was a little against it. But I listened to my lawyer and tax man.... I don't want to reach out from the grave to control them, ... but the way the trusts are set up, my grandchildren will have to work.

Mr. Ring's heirs will not begin to receive their inheritances until they approach their thirties. While some affluent grandparents give their grandchildren products and privileges, the Rings give them educations. Such gifts are intended to enhance their grandchildren's discipline, ambition, and independence.